

# Peer Review: Initial Project Results

E483/E583 Information Visualization | Spring 2026 | Indiana University



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## Review 1: Team H

*Project Title: Mapping & Analyzing Participation in Tutor/Mentor Leadership and Networking Conferences*

### 1. Quality of Data Selection, Cleaning, Preparation, and Documentation

The intermediate report does a good job of documenting how the data was cleaned. The team describes the SNA Category field normalization in detail, explaining how many inconsistent raw variants were mapped to a standard set of canonical categories. This kind of step-by-step documentation makes the cleaning process easy to follow and reproduce.

The team also acknowledges the remaining data quality issues, such as blank organization records and missing website URLs for many participants. Being upfront about these limitations is helpful for anyone building on this work in the future.

One thing I would suggest is that the team provide a bit more explanation for how they handled the blank organization records in the analysis. Since a notable portion of records are affected, it would be useful to know whether these were excluded, treated as unknowns, or handled some other way, and what effect that might have on the results.

### 2. Appropriate Selection of Tools, Algorithms, Workflows, and Parameter Values

The tools chosen by Team H seem well suited to the project. Using Kumu.io for the network map makes sense because it is designed for exactly this kind of interactive relationship visualization. The choice to use Python for data cleaning and Plotly for the participation frequency chart is reasonable, and the team explains these choices clearly.

I also appreciate that the team decided to build on top of the previous student team's work rather than starting from scratch. This is a practical decision that shows good project awareness. The explanation for why the Kumu.io interactive export was deferred to the final sprint is clear and logical.

One thing I feel is missing is a description of the specific parameter choices for the network analysis, such as how edges between nodes will be weighted, and what threshold will be used for the fuzzy string matching that is planned for adding website URLs. Including these details would make the methodology section more complete.

### 3. Quality of Data Analysis, Visualization Results, and Discussion of Insights Gained

The team has found some meaningful patterns in the data. The finding that about half of all attendance records belong to the Program category is interesting, especially since it was uncovered only after the normalization step. The observation about conference attendance peaking in the late 1990s and declining in later years is also a useful insight that stakeholders would appreciate.

The interactive participation chart that filters by year, sector, and state is a strong feature. It addresses the needs of different stakeholder groups at the same time, which is good design thinking.

I would encourage the team to go deeper in the discussion of insights. For example, it would be helpful to explain why certain sectors like Faith and Foundation have very low representation, or what the geographic data outside of Chicago tells us. Right now the interpretation section identifies the patterns but does not say much about what they might mean for the client's mission.

#### **4. Completeness and Quality of Validation and Redesign**

The validation section in the intermediate report is one of the strongest parts of this submission. The team gathered feedback from three reviewers with different backgrounds, clearly documented what worked and what did not, and then made specific design changes based on that feedback. Removing the individual name search for privacy reasons and adding a dedicated page for the previous team's work are both well-reasoned decisions.

For the next round of testing, I would suggest the team try to define clearer success criteria before running usability sessions. For example, deciding in advance what a successful interaction looks like, such as a user being able to find a specific organization without any help, would make the evaluation results easier to interpret and act on.

#### **5. Overall Quality of Content, Communication, and Attribution**

Overall, I found this report to be well organized and easy to read. The stakeholder analysis is detailed and practical, and the team connects each stakeholder's needs to specific design decisions. The references are appropriate and show that the team is giving credit to the right people and sources, including the client and the previous student team.

I also noticed that the team is transparent about how they used AI tools, which I appreciate. They explain what tasks were given to AI and where the outputs were reviewed and corrected, which is the right way to handle this.

One area for improvement is the discussion of limitations. The dataset covers conferences only up to 2015, which means the network map does not reflect more than a decade of activity. Acknowledging this and discussing what it means for the client's use of the tool would strengthen the write-up. A few sentences in the analysis section are also quite long and could be split up for better readability.

